DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

The Power of God's Names: Why Kabbalah Is Not Magic

Derech Hashem 3:2:5-6

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 2, paragraphs 5-6 (from the middle of paragraph 5) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 18 November 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

Chapter 1 described the parts of the soul and what happens in sleep. Chapter 2 opened with two ideas. Everything physical has a spiritual source and comes down through a chain, but it is possible to cut out the chain and go to the source, and so affect nature. And it is possible for a person to be released a little from the constraints of the body and connect more with the spirit. On Monday we saw that the root of everything is the Kadosh Barukh Hu, so a person who connects to Him directly is on a different level altogether.

Paragraph 5: God's name brings down light

The Ramhal continues: God wished to be called by His name, so that we could arouse ourselves to mention Him. For this He has His unique name, "this is My name forever", which the Rabbi again identified as probably the forty-two letter name. Through it one connects to the original source and can skip the whole chain.

God decreed that when His creatures mention His name, illumination and light are drawn down, as it says, "in every place where I cause My name to be mentioned, I will come to you and bless you". And the kind of light depends on how one addresses Him.

"This sentence is what the whole of Kabbalah is about." Different combinations of God's names are used at different times, because different lights need to be drawn down at different times: one on the night of Pesah, another on Shavuot. To put it "crudely, in a crass way", you are pressing different buttons. But even this has its framework. Mentioning a name is not magic; it needs a person who understands what the name is about.

Learning Kabbalah and practising it

There has always been a distinction between learning Kabbalah and practising it. Learning it, once a person has learned enough Torah, is fine. Practising it is "a whole different story". The Rabbi recalled his parents' warnings about practical Kabbalah, and said it is written that one who practises it improperly can end up with problems. The reason is simple: when you go to

the source and bypass the normal rules, it can backfire on you or on the people you used it for. "Actually doing what we're learning now is extremely dangerous. You only do it if you know 100% what you're doing."

A participant asked whether the names of God are finite. The Rabbi said they are infinite: ten sefirot, each containing ten, and so on without end. He described the Siddur HaRashash, where a single word of the prayer can take a whole page of names and kavanot. He has prayed with such people: they began at sunrise and finished at three or four in the afternoon, since every word needs its kavanah. These are unique people, "it's not for" everyone.

The second effect: a higher understanding

Apart from bypassing nature, these names also let a person connect to the spiritual realms and reach a higher understanding than ordinary intellect. Not because he has become more spiritual, but because his body has less power over him and the soul can express itself more. This is the beginning of the levels of Ruah HaKodesh and prophecy, which the Ramhal will explain later. The means is the names, either by thinking about them, saying them, or combining them, always with the proper conditions.

So meditating on God's names lets a person (a) bypass nature, because he is connected to the divine itself, and (b) be released from the constraints of the physical world and gain deeper understanding.

Paragraph 6: everything has levels

It is not black and white, connected or not. The connection can be loose or tight, and the effect greater or smaller. Some are released from physical constraint completely, some far less.

So this is not purely academic. "Even us simple people, we may be able to get this on a very, very small level." The Rabbi described those moments when we feel beyond our physical constraints, or know something we should not be able to know, or suddenly understand something existential and our mindset changes. That is being released, a little, from the physical.

"God isn't a vending machine"

Before the Ramhal says it himself later, the Rabbi wanted to prevent a misunderstanding. All of this works only when done in the right way. God is not a vending machine whose buttons you can press. Saying names and reading kavanot with no idea of what they mean, while sinning the rest of the time, is terrible. Since there are two parallel systems, such a person may well be connecting to the divine, but to the negative side.

He showed a siddur with simple kavanot printed in it, and said the problem is that simple people pick it up, find the names exciting, and start using them. "These things are wrong."

The class ended with participants recalling hakhamim who prayed with kavanot, the long shofar blasts of one hakham on Rosh Hashanah, and a question about Yaakov and the speckled sheep, which the Rabbi took off the recording.

Summary

- Mentioning God's name draws down light, and the kind of light depends on the name used; this is the root of Kabbalah.
- Learning Kabbalah is one thing; practising it is dangerous and can backfire.
- The names of God are endless in their combinations; praying with full kavanot is for unique people.
- These powers come in levels, and even ordinary people can taste a little of them.
- God is not a vending machine: without understanding and good conduct, using names connects to the wrong side.

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